Pembrolizumab + cisplatin + fluorouracil

Pembrolizumab and chemotherapy aim to control head and neck cancer that has spread or returned and cannot be removed. Your team explains the expected benefit, uncertainty and alternatives for you.

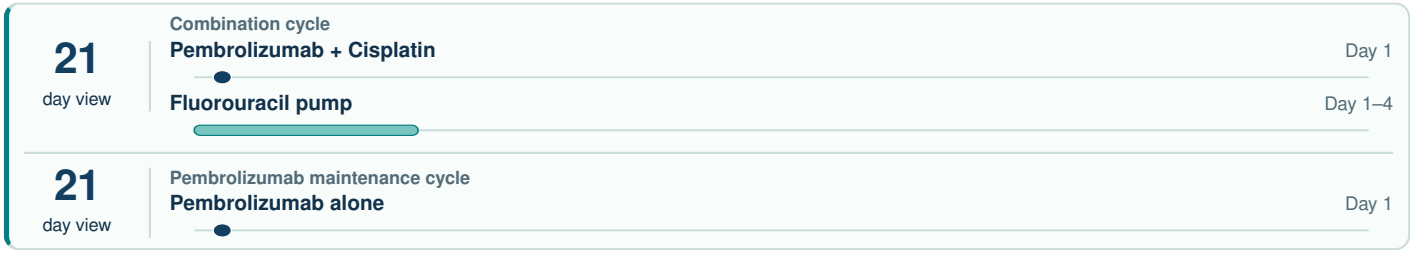
First-line treatment of metastatic or unresectable recurrent head and neck squamous cell carcinoma in adults with tumour PD-L1 CPS ≥1. · NCCP 00706 v3 · Document revised 10 November 2026

Your personal plan: this is the standard regimen schedule. Your team confirms your prescribed doses, cycles, treatment changes and appointments in your written plan.

First-line treatment of metastatic or unresectable recurrent head and neck squamous cell carcinoma in adults with tumour PD-L1 CPS ≥1.

My overall treatment

Every 3 weeks; up to 6 combination cycles, then pembrolizumab alone.



Combination treatment
Day 1 infusions; fluorouracil over Days 1–4. Four 22-hour or two 48-hour infusions as prescribed.

Pembrolizumab alone
Pembrolizumab alone every 3 weeks while appropriate; no automatic 24-month stop.

A typical 21-day cycle

Day 1	Day 2–4	Day 5–21
Infusions and pump connection	Fluorouracil continues	Recovery and review

Timing may change after review. Side effects can occur on any day; there are no guaranteed safe days.

My tests and checks

When	What is checked	Timing / reason
Before	**Baseline safety and preparation** NCCP / individual plan	Blood count, kidneys/liver, glucose, thyroid, hepatitis tests, PD-L1 and dihydropyrimidine dehydrogenase (a medicine-processing enzyme) (DPD); other checks if indicated.
During	**Bloods and symptoms** NCCP	Blood count, kidneys/liver and glucose each cycle; thyroid every 3–6 weeks. Report immune symptoms.
After / response	**Follow-up and tests** NCCP / individual plan	Report immune effects after stopping. Scans, examinations and ongoing tests follow your individual plan.

Between treatments

- Pump changes/disconnection follow the prescribed option. Call early for diarrhoea, mouth pain or chest symptoms.
- Immune symptoms can arise during maintenance or after stopping.

Bring your medicine list, test dates, treatment calendar and actual urgent contacts.

When to get help
Call 112 / 999 for severe breathing difficulty, severe chest pain, collapse or a seizure.
Call oncology immediately: temperature 37.5°C or above, 36°C or below, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell, even with a normal temperature. Follow your hospital's temperature instructions. If you cannot reach the team, seek urgent medical assessment. Do not wait for the next appointment.

Oncology daytime: 087 12345678 · **Out of hours:** 087 87654321
EXAMPLE ONLY — team must replace both numbers before patient use.

Feasibility build. Clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending. Your team confirms your personal plan.

What to watch for

You do not need to know which medicine caused a symptom before calling.

1 Head / hormones / eyes

Pembrolizumab

Report severe headache, visual change, unusual weakness, thirst, dizziness or frequent urination.

3 Lungs / breathing

Pembrolizumab

New cough or breathlessness needs prompt assessment; severe breathing difficulty is an emergency.

5 Liver

Pembrolizumab + chemotherapy

Blood tests may show inflammation first. Report yellow skin or eyes, dark urine or unusual itching.

7 Bowels / abdomen

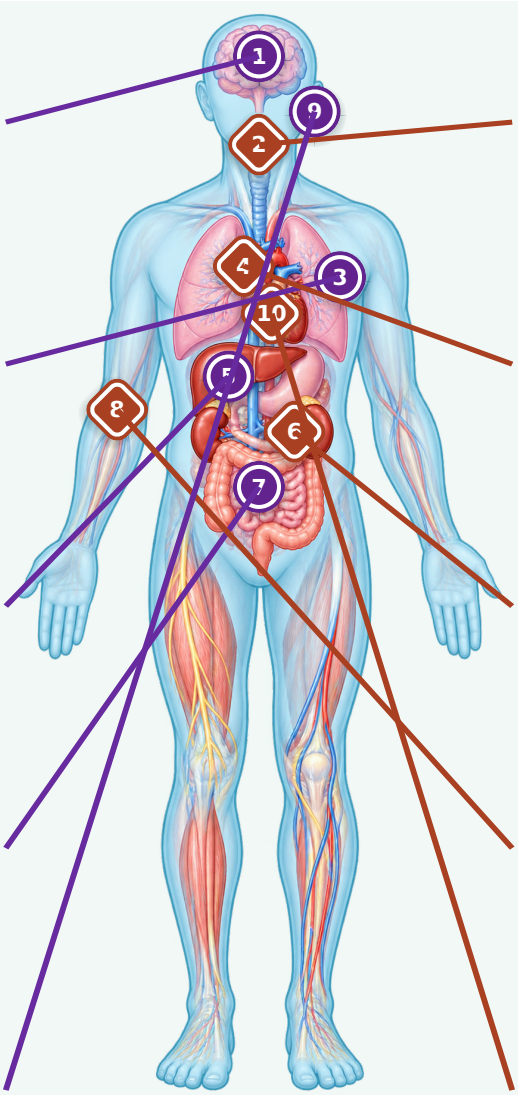
Fluorouracil + pembrolizumab

Call early for diarrhoea, blood or mucus, pain or dehydration. Different causes need different treatment.

9 Hearing / nerves

Cisplatin

Report tinnitus, hearing change, tingling, weakness or balance problems before the next dose.



2 Mouth / throat

Fluorouracil

Report ulcers, painful swallowing or difficulty drinking; early severe symptoms need urgent review.

4 Heart / chest

Fluorouracil + pembrolizumab

Chest pain, palpitations, collapse or marked muscle weakness needs urgent assessment.

6 Kidneys / fluids

Cisplatin + pembrolizumab

Report reduced urine, swelling, persistent vomiting or difficulty drinking; kidney results also guide platinum treatment.

8 Skin / hands / feet

Fluorouracil + pembrolizumab

Report rash, painful palms or soles. Blistering, peeling or rash with fever needs urgent assessment.

10 Blood cells / infection

Chemotherapy

Fever, shivering, sudden illness, unusual bruising or bleeding needs prompt oncology advice.

Selected effects, not every possible effect or a prediction. Blood-count, skin and line markers are schematic. Number and text carry meaning; colour is decorative.

Call the oncology team promptly for fever, sudden illness, diarrhoea, painful mouth, reduced drinking, new breathlessness or immune symptoms. Chest pain during or after fluorouracil needs urgent assessment. Severe chest pain, breathing difficulty, collapse or a seizure is an emergency. Early severe fluorouracil symptoms can occur despite DPD testing.

When to get help

Call 112 / 999 for severe breathing difficulty, severe chest pain, collapse or a seizure.

Call oncology immediately: temperature 37.5°C or above, 36°C or below, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell, even with a normal temperature. Follow your hospital's temperature instructions. If you cannot reach the team, seek urgent medical assessment. Do not wait for the next appointment.

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Keep your treatment details to hand

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Print this page **one-sided on A4 at Actual size / 100%**. Cut only the dashed outer border around both panels. **Do not cut the centre line.** Fold with FRONT and BACK facing out, then glue or tape the blank backs together. Finished size: **85.6 × 54 mm**. Keep the stamp side writable.

FRONT / CONTACTS

My Treatment Card

SACTCheck

Name: _____

Pembrolizumab + cisplatin + 5-FU

Every 3 weeks; up to 6 combination cycles, then pembrolizumab alone.

Phase: _____ Planned cycles: 6

Daytime (EXAMPLE) 087 12345678
Out of hours (EXAMPLE) 087 87654321

Unwell or fever? Call oncology now.
Severe breathing difficulty, chest pain or collapse: **112 / 999.**

EXAMPLE NUMBERS — replace before patient use.

CUT outer border

BACK / TREATMENT RECORD

My cycle record

Team stamps after each completed cycle.

C1 Date / initials	C2 Date / initials	C3 Date / initials
C4 Date / initials	C5 Date / initials	C6 Date / initials

My treatment information

Plan changed? Ask the team to update this card.

FOLD centre — do not cut

Keep the record accurate

The team dates and initials each recorded treatment unit when complete. A cycle is complete after its final planned dose; a weekly-treatment stamp records that weekly dose. Delays, omitted doses or a changed plan need a note or a replacement card. A stamp does not approve the next treatment. Keep any medicine-specific alert card too.

Put your treatment page on your phone

Scan your QR and check the treatment name. Save that page to your home screen.

iPhone / Safari

Tap Share → Add to Home Screen. Select Open as Web App if offered, then Add.

Android / Chrome

Tap the three-dot menu → Add to Home screen or Install and create shortcut. Choose the shortcut option and confirm.

Menu wording varies. The QR opens information, not a personal record. Paper stamps do not update the website. Check that the saved icon opens the correct treatment.

Your local contacts and resources

Oncology daytime: 087 12345678 · **Out of hours:** 087 87654321

EXAMPLE ONLY — team must replace both numbers before patient use.

Hospital / team: _____
Backup if the team cannot be reached: _____

Additional local services and resources will be added when confirmed. Your team must check and complete this page before patient use.

Feasibility build. Clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending. Your team confirms your personal plan.